officer of Air India. I could hardly devote any time to the winding up, packing and shipping, but Urmila managed that with the ever-efficient logistic support from the Delhi office of the Reserve Bank.

There are many perks attached to the governor's job; among them, the colonial-era governor's bungalow on the posh Carmichael Road, since renamed M.L. Dahanukar Marg, is possibly the most valued. The location of the bungalow is itself symbolic of the sharp contrasts that are so characteristic of Mumbai. Along the road are the homes of some of the richest corporate leaders of the country with snazzy houses and flashy cars, and just down the cliff, a slum, one of hundreds in Mumbai, sheltering migrants from villages across the country who come in pursuit of a livelihood to this 'maximum city' of hope, enterprise and opportunity.

Y.V. Reddy had vacated the bungalow within a couple of days of handing over to me but I continued to stay in the Reserve Bank guest house on Nepean Sea Road as the bank's maintenance staff asked for a couple of weeks to undertake some long-pending repairs and restoration. Even as the staff got to the job with alacrity, the two weeks turned into two months as the governor's bungalow is a heritage building, and any alteration or replacement, from floor tiles to woodwork to wall colour, requires the clearance of the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS). In the event, some chipped floor tiles remained, as our engineers could not produce a replacement 'colonial era tile' which could pass muster with the BNHS. I am not complaining though, as the BNHS surveillance ensures that the bungalow maintains its period-piece decorum and gentle charm.

Living in the bungalow was a happy and comfortable experience. What I liked most of all was its spaciousness and generous proportions. The irony of living in such a large house when it was just the two of us, as we had lived in matchbox-like government housing in Delhi when our two sons were of the running and jumping age, was not lost on Urmila and me.

I must confess that we—Urmila and I—never really got around to doing full justice to that magnificent habitation, caught up as we were in our respective jobs which involved extensive travel too. But we did try to grab every opportunity possible to invite family and friends over so that these